

About World War II (1939–1945)

THE RISE OF TOTALITARIANISM IN EUROPE

World War I left Europe physically, financially, and psychologically exhausted—and eager to avoid further conflict. In some countries, this opened the door for the rise of strong, nationalist, totalitarian leaders who would eventually lead the world back into war.

Fascist Italy

In 1919, Italian journalist Benito Mussolini formed *fasci di combattimento*, anti-socialist “fighting leagues” that became known as Fascists. The Fascists attacked socialist newspapers and used violence to break up labor unions, farmers’ collectives, and local government. Unable to stop the violence, the national government lost public support.

In 1921, the *fasci di combattimento* officially became the Fascist Party and won a block of seats in that year’s parliamentary elections. Mussolini manipulated the situation to increase his power and influence and that of his Blackshirts, so named for the Fascist uniforms. In 1922, Mussolini and his Blackshirts marched on Rome and took over key locations in the capital city. To avoid civil war, Italian king Victor Emmanuel asked Mussolini to form a new Italian government.

Mussolini used his new role as prime minister to rule Italy with dictatorial power. Only the Roman Catholic Church remained officially outside his control (although the Vatican did support him at first). Under Mussolini’s rule, Italy became a one-party state, and free speech was abolished. The Fascists launched a series of expensive and ambitious public works projects and won support from many Italians who believed Mussolini was restoring Italy’s dignity and economic stability.

Nazi Germany

Austrian by birth, Adolf Hitler served in the German army during World War I. At war’s end in November 1918, he was in the hospital. When he was released in 1919, he joined a small political party called the German Workers’ Party, and a year later, he was put in charge of the party’s propaganda campaigns. In 1921, he maneuvered himself into position as the party’s sole leader. Using propaganda and his own charisma, he capitalized on German resentment over defeat in World War I and the terms of the Versailles Treaty to build support for himself and the party, now renamed Nationalsozialistische Deutsche Arbeiterpartei, or Nazi Party. Still, the party remained comparatively small and localized in the area of Munich.

In 1923, Hitler and several colleagues launched a putsch, or revolt, in Munich in hopes of sparking a revolution that would overthrow Germany’s democratic Weimar government. The putsch failed, and Hitler was sent to prison, where he dictated an account of his political beliefs and history. Chief among these beliefs was the idea of a superior “Aryan race.” Hitler’s account was published as a book titled *Mein Kampf* (*My Struggle*).

With a new strategy that focused his efforts on attaining government power through legal means, Hitler resumed his quest after his release from prison. Opportunity presented itself when the Great Depression hit Germany. Using his propaganda skills and capitalizing on the government’s failure to address the depression, Hitler garnered national support for the Nazi Party. In the 1932 elections, the Nazis won more seats in Germany’s parliament than any other party. The next year, Hitler was appointed chancellor. Over the next two years, Hitler consolidated his power to make Germany a Nazi dictatorship under his leadership.

Under Hitler's leadership, the Nazi Party continued to garner public support through massive public works projects that reduced widespread unemployment in the country and through propaganda campaigns that fed German nationalism and fanned German anti-Semitism. Loyalty to the Nazi government was enforced by police organizations such as the SS.

Stalin and the U.S.S.R.

Born in the Georgian region of Russia, Joseph Stalin—born Joseph Dzhugashvili—joined the militant communist Bolsheviks in the first years of the 1900s. He was repeatedly imprisoned and exiled by the czarist government for his revolutionary activity. After the Bolsheviks seized power and during Russia's civil war, Stalin served in the Bolshevik government. In 1922, he was named secretary general of the Communist Party, a position he held until his death in 1953.

After Vladimir Lenin's death in 1924, Stalin built a cult around himself and used his positions as secretary general and politburo (policy-making committee) member to set himself up as dictator. Among his first acts were the dismissal, expulsion, and execution of his rivals, including the revered Leon Trotsky.

In 1928, Stalin launched ambitious programs to industrialize the Soviet Union and collectivize Soviet agriculture into massive state-owned farms. The collectivization program proved especially devastating, disrupting the normal food production cycle and launching the country into an extended famine. In addition, farmers who resisted collectivization were rounded up and sent to Siberian labor camps. Ukraine, then a region within the U.S.S.R., was hit particularly hard by these changes, which are known today as the Holodomar, which means "death or killing by hunger." It is estimated that around ten million farmers died as a result of Stalin's policies. Stalin's industrialization plans were not as destructive, and they did eventually succeed. Still, the industrialization policies had their own failures, which led to show trials and the imprisonment or execution of numerous industrial managers.

The 1930s in the Stalinist U.S.S.R. were characterized by the Great Purge, an extended campaign of political terror in which Stalin pushed out rivals and dissenters from the Communist Party through a series of show trials, forced confessions, and executions.

THE WORLD MOVES TOWARD WAR

Italy's Invasion of Ethiopia

Mussolini sought to expand Italy's power (and distract Italians from growing economic problems) by building a colonial empire. He set his sights on Ethiopia, which had defeated an Italian invasion in 1896. In October 1935, Italian forces attacked Ethiopia. Haile Selassie, Ethiopia's ruler, sought help from the League of Nations, the international organization created after World War I. The League was slow to respond, and when it did, it did so ineffectively, by issuing sanctions that had little effect on Italy. As a result, Mussolini's forces successfully conquered Ethiopia, creating an Italian East African empire.

The Spanish Civil War

The Spanish Civil War (1936–1939) was Europe's first bloody conflict after World War I and served as a dress rehearsal for the global conflict that was to come. The war began on July 17, 1936, when the Nationalists, led by Generals Emilio Mola and Francisco Franco, attempted to overthrow Spain's democratically elected republican government. The Nationalists were able to seize large rural areas of the country but faced strong opposition in the cities.

Both sides called for international aid. Stalin's U.S.S.R. and volunteers from Europe and the United States supported the government. Mussolini and Hitler aligned with Franco's Nationalists.

Hitler, and to some extent Mussolini, used the war as an opportunity to test their militaries and military technology in real battlefield conditions. One such example was the bombing of Guernica, in which the German air force terror-bombed and almost completely destroyed the town. The devastation is immortalized in Pablo Picasso's painting *Guernica* (1937).

In March 1939, the Spanish government fled the country, and Franco's Nationalists entered the capital unopposed. Within twenty-four hours, the civil war was over. From that point until his death in 1975, Francisco Franco ruled Spain as a dictator.

Hitler Seeks "Living Space"

The Treaty of Versailles had placed severe limits on Germany's military. That treaty and the Treaty of Locarno (1925) also placed limits on Germany's territory. Starting in the mid-1930s, Hitler began to test these limits. He introduced the draft, increasing the size of the German army, and expanded the production of weapons. In 1936, he sent troops into the Rhineland, a demilitarized area along Germany's border with Belgium and France. Britain and France protested but did not take retaliatory action.

In 1937, Germany, Italy, and Japan formalized an alliance, and Hitler planned further German expansion in Europe. His first step was to "unite" all German-speaking peoples in Europe, beginning with the invasion and annexation of Austria in 1938. Hitler then moved against Czechoslovakia, demanding that the region called Sudetenland, which had a large German-speaking population, be surrendered to Germany. Leaders from Britain, France, Italy, and Germany met in Munich and agreed to Hitler's demand in exchange for an assurance that Hitler would not seek further territory. Czechoslovakia was not involved in the negotiations. Six months later, Hitler violated the Munich Agreement and occupied the rest of Czechoslovakia.

By the summer of 1939, it was clear that Hitler had turned his attention to conquest of the non-German populations of Europe, beginning with Poland. Finally realizing that Hitler could not be trusted, Britain and France guaranteed Poland's independence.

Hitler, meanwhile, wanted to ensure that his invasion of Poland would not result in a two-front war, against Britain and France in the west and against the U.S.S.R. in the east. He and Stalin agreed to a nonaggression pact in which they agreed to not fight each other and to divide eastern Europe into German and Russian spheres of influence.

Japanese Expansion in Asia

Japanese expansion began in 1910, with the annexation of Korea, but increased in scope and intensity during the 1930s. During the 1920s, Japan lacked a unified government, and by the 1930s, the military was acting almost unilaterally abroad and with increasing authority at home.

The military saw territorial expansion as a way for Japan to gain economic independence and end the country's reliance on imports, especially gas and oil. In 1931, Japanese military forces occupied Manchuria, a northeastern region of China. The next year, they renamed Manchuria "Manchukuo" and established a puppet government. The League of Nations condemned Japanese involvement in Manchuria. Japan responded by withdrawing from the League.

In 1936, Japan formed alliances with Nazi Germany and Fascist Italy, forming what would become the Axis Powers in World War II. The next year, Japan invaded China. The first battle of that conflict—the Marco Polo Bridge Incident—is considered by many historians to be the first battle of World War II.

THE WORLD AT WAR (1937–1941)

Asia

From the Marco Polo Bridge, the Japanese army continued its march through China, capturing Shanghai and Beijing and laying siege to Nanjing. The conquest of China was the beginning of Japan's creation of the Greater East Asia Co-prosperity Sphere, essentially an Asian empire controlled by Japan. The empire would provide the resources that Japan needed and allow Japan to end its dependence on the West. From China, Japan expanded its empire into French Indochina (known today as Vietnam, Cambodia, and Laos). Angered by Japan's invasions, the United States placed an embargo on Japan, cutting off its supply of American scrap steel and oil, and froze Japan's American financial assets. Japan's military, now in charge of the country's government, made plans to retaliate against the United States. In the early morning hours of December 7, 1941, they put those plans into action and attacked the U.S. naval base at Pearl Harbor in Hawaii.

Europe and North Africa (1939–1941)

As expected, on September 1, 1939, Hitler invaded Poland. Within days, Britain and France declared war on Germany. Using a strategy called blitzkrieg, or "lightning war," Hitler's forces continued their march across Europe, conquering Belgium, Holland, and France. The German army pinned British forces in northern France on the beach at Dunkirk, but the British managed a historic retreat to safety across the English Channel.

The United States, although not a combatant in the war, made it clear that it sided with Britain and France. After France fell, Congress approved the Lend-Lease Act, which made it easier for the United States to provide aid to Britain and, later, China and the Soviet Union.

In July 1940, Hitler began a prolonged air attack on the United Kingdom. Known as the Battle of Britain, it became one of Hitler's few defeats. That did not stop Hitler from conquering other countries. His forces moved into the Balkans, Turkey, Iraq, Syria, and North Africa.

In 1941, Hitler broke his nonaggression pact with Stalin and invaded the Soviet Union while continuing his attacks against Britain. The Nazi invasion of the U.S.S.R. caught Soviet forces by surprise, but the Soviets recovered quickly and fought with a determination the Germans had not expected. As a result, German forces were caught in Soviet territory in winter, unprepared for the severity of Russian winters.

Meanwhile, the Soviet Union officially allied with Britain and the United States, and together, the British and the Soviets defeated German forces in Iran and North Africa.

THE UNITED STATES JOINS THE WAR (1941–1945)

Europe

After Japan's attack on Pearl Harbor, the United States declared war on Japan and Germany. Together with Britain and the Soviet Union, the United States decided to first defeat Hitler in Europe and then take on Japan in Asia.

In 1942 and 1943, the German army suffered defeat at Stalingrad in the Soviet Union, a turning point that began the German retreat out of the U.S.S.R. The first U.S. troops arrived in Europe in 1942 but did not see action until 1943. That year, Allied forces invaded North Africa and Italy, causing Italy to surrender. Germany now stood alone in Europe.

By 1944, the Germans were fighting the Allies on two fronts: Italy and eastern Europe. Allied leadership decided the time was right to open a third front, in northern Europe. That June, the Allies launched D-Day, the largest amphibious landing in history, on the beaches of Normandy in northern France. From there, British, American, and Canadian forces effected the beginning of the German retreat out of western Europe. The German army's last stand in western Europe occurred in Belgium at the Battle of the Bulge, which British Prime Minister Winston Churchill called "the greatest American battle of the war."

In April 1945, Soviet forces moving from the east met American forces moving from the west. Together, they marched toward Germany's capital, Berlin. On April 30, Hitler committed suicide. Roughly a week later, Germany surrendered. The war in Europe was over.

Asia

After the attack on Pearl Harbor, Japanese forces continued their conquest of Asia, occupying the Philippines, the Dutch East Indies (present-day Indonesia), Burma (present-day Myanmar), and Malaya (present-day Singapore and Malaysia). Meanwhile, the United States rebuilt its navy, and although it had agreed to defeat Hitler first, it also engaged against Japan in the Pacific. An air unit called the Flying Tigers went into action in China and Burma. In June 1942, after a victory in the Battle of Midway, the U.S. Navy began a strategy of island-hopping—advancing toward Japan one island at a time, cutting off Japan's supply lines along the way. By 1944, U.S. forces were within bombing distance of Japan. Some of the fiercest, bloodiest fighting of the island-hopping campaign occurred in Iwo Jima and Okinawa in early 1945.

In July 1945, the United States completed its development of a new weapon, the atomic bomb. In August, after Japan refused a U.S. call for surrender, the United States dropped atomic bombs on the Japanese cities of Hiroshima and Nagasaki. Between those bombings, Soviet forces invaded Japanese-held Manchuria. A week later, Japan surrendered and was placed under U.S. military rule. The formal surrender papers were signed on September 2, 1945.

The American Home Front

After Congress declared war on December 8, 1941, Americans from all walks of life mobilized for war. Millions of American men joined the military. American factories ramped up to become an "arsenal for democracy," in the words of President Roosevelt. Rosie the Riveter became an iconic symbol of the millions of women who joined the workforce in support of the war effort. Other women provided direct military support through the WAACs (army), WAVEs (navy), and WASPs (air force) and as army nurses.

To ensure sufficient resources for the war effort, the government instituted a system of rationing. Americans were given coupon books that determined how much sugar, coffee, meat, canned food, and other groceries each family could buy. Families were also encouraged to grow their own fresh produce in personal gardens. Price controls were instituted so that the limited quantities of goods would not lead to inflation.

Internment of Japanese Americans

In December 1941, around 120,000 Japanese Americans lived in the United States, mainly in Western states. Most were American-born citizens. In the wake of the Pearl Harbor attack, these Americans faced virulent racism that led to the government incarcerating them in internment camps across the United States.

In February 1942, two months after Pearl Harbor, and fueled by unfounded fears of sabotage and espionage, President Roosevelt issued Executive Order 9066, which authorized the U.S. military to evacuate all Japanese Americans in the West to "relocation centers" away from the coast. By August 1942, approximately 112,000 Japanese Americans of all ages had been stripped of their property and most of their possessions and sent to internment camps in remote locations in California, Utah, Idaho, Arizona, and Arkansas. Once in these camps,

inmates lived under military supervision in multifamily barracks with shared restrooms. Food and other necessities were rationed, and schools were set up for the youth in the camps.

In 1943 and 1944, young men from the camps were recruited to serve in the U.S. Army in Europe. Their unit, the 442nd Regimental Combat Team, became the war's most decorated unit.

When the war ended, the camps were disbanded, but few Japanese Americans returned to their previous hometowns. Their lives had been disrupted forever. In 1988, Congress and the president publicly acknowledged the injustice of Japanese American internment and paid reparations to the internees.

AFTER THE WAR

War Crimes Trials

The Nuremberg Trials

As Allied forces moved into and across eastern Europe, they encountered the unimaginable horrors of what has become known as the Holocaust. As early as the 1930s, Hitler and the Nazis had launched anti-Jewish campaigns in Germany and other Nazi-controlled territory. They stripped Jewish citizens of their rights and then forced Jewish people into crowded, walled-in ghettos before instituting what they called the "final solution," the genocide of Europe's Jewish population through the use of labor and death camps across eastern Europe. It was these concentration camps that Allied forces found and liberated as they pushed Nazi forces back to Germany. By that time, six million of Europe's 9.5 million Jews had been killed.

When the war ended, those who were responsible for these camps, from government ministers to camp guards, were put on trial for crimes against humanity for their role in the Holocaust. The trials were held in Nuremberg, Germany, where Hitler had first declared the laws that robbed German Jews of their citizenship.

The Tokyo War Crimes Trials

The Pacific theater was not free of atrocities either. As it conquered Asia, the Japanese military committed war crimes such as the use of civilians for bayonet practice, rape and sexual enslavement of women, and abuse of prisoners of war, including forced labor and death marches. From 1946 to 1948, Japanese leaders, including former prime minister Tojo, were put on trial for war crimes, crimes against peace, and crimes against humanity.

The United Nations

In 1943, while the war was still ongoing, Allied leaders agreed to establish an organization for international cooperation after the war. In 1945, the plans for that organization were finalized, and the United Nations (U.N.) was born.

The U.N. was—and is—made up of a General Assembly with representatives from every member nation, an eleven-member Security Council, an International Court of Justice, and various social, cultural, and economic councils and committees.

The U.N.'s primary goal is to settle disputes between nations peacefully, although it does have provisions for military intervention as a peacekeeping force in some situations. The U.N. has also been a forum for international cooperation on issues of human rights, global health, child welfare, historic preservation, and environmental protection.